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1. ABOUT THIS POLICY

Simtec Consult Limited is committed to protecting the health, safety and wellbeing of its staff. We recognise the importance of identifying and tackling the causes of work-related stress. We also recognise that personal stress, while unrelated to the workplace, can adversely affect the wellbeing of staff at work.

The purpose of this policy is to set out the measures we have in place to support the mental wellbeing of all our staff.

This policy does not form part of any contract of employment or other contract to provide services, and we may amend it at any time.

Any information provided to Simtec about an individual's health will be processed in accordance with our Data Protection and Retention Policy. We recognise that such data is sensitive and will handle it confidentially.

2. WHO DOES THIS POLICY APPLY TO?

This policy applies to all employees, officers, consultants, self-employed contractors, casual workers, agency workers, volunteers and interns.

3. WHO IS RESPONSIBLE FOR THIS POLICY?

The Managing Director has overall responsibility for the effective operation of this policy. Day-to-day implementation is supported by the Health and Safety Lead. Suggestions for changes should be reported to either of them.

Questions about the day-to-day application of this policy should be referred to the relevant line manager, the Managing Director or the Health and Safety Lead in the first instance.

This policy will be reviewed annually by the Managing Director and Health and Safety Lead.

4. LEGAL OBLIGATIONS

We have a legal duty to take reasonable care to ensure that staff health is not put at risk by excessive pressures or demands arising from the way work is organised.

This policy takes account of our obligations under the Health and Safety at Work etc. Act 1974, Management of Health and Safety at Work Regulations 1999, Employment Rights Act 1996, Protection from Harassment Act 1997, Working Time Regulations 1998 and Equality Act 2010.

5. UNDERSTANDING STRESS AND MENTAL HEALTH

Stress is the adverse reaction people have to excessive pressures or demands placed on them. Stress is not an illness but, sustained over a period of time, it can lead to mental and/or physical illness.

Mental health describes our emotional, psychological and social wellbeing. It affects how we think, feel and act and how we cope with the normal pressures of everyday life. Positive mental health is rarely an absolute state because factors inside and outside work affect mental health, meaning that we move on a spectrum that ranges from good to poor mental health.

There is an important distinction between working under pressure and experiencing stress. Certain levels of pressure are acceptable and normal in every job. They can improve performance, enable

individuals to meet their potential and provide a sense of achievement and job satisfaction. However, when pressure becomes excessive it produces stress and undermines mental health.

Pressures outside the workplace, whether arising from unexpected or traumatic events such as accidents, illness, bereavement, family breakdown or financial worries, can result in stress and poor mental health. They can also compound normal workplace pressures.

We recognise that individuals react to similar situations in different ways and that what triggers stress and poor mental health varies from person to person.

6. OUR APPROACH TO MENTAL WELLBEING IN THE WORKPLACE

Simtec will:

- promote a culture of open communication by providing formal and informal channels through which staff can raise concerns;
- take account of stress and mental wellbeing when planning and allocating workloads and provide opportunities to discuss these matters through regular one-to-one discussions;
- monitor working hours and additional work to help ensure staff are not overworking, and encourage staff to use their holiday entitlement;
- ensure that risk assessments include or specifically address work-related stress where appropriate;
- consider requests for flexible working in accordance with applicable law and business requirements;
- design change-management arrangements to minimise unnecessary uncertainty and stress where workplace reorganisation occurs;
- maintain procedures to address harassment, bullying, victimisation and other inappropriate behaviour;
- provide appropriate information and guidance to help staff recognise work-related stress and mental ill health and protect their own wellbeing and that of colleagues;
- consider appropriate external medical or occupational-health advice and reasonable workplace support for staff affected by, or absent because of, stress or mental ill health.

7. SUPPORTING THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THIS POLICY

7.1 All staff

All staff should familiarise themselves with this policy and act in accordance with its aims and objectives. Staff should plan and organise their work to meet personal and organisational objectives and co-operate with support, advice and guidance offered by line managers, the Managing Director or the Health and Safety Lead.

Anyone who experiences or becomes aware of a situation that may result in work-related stress or undermine mental wellbeing at work should raise the matter with their line manager, the Managing Director or the Health and Safety Lead.

7.2 Managers

Managers have a responsibility to recognise potential issues of work-related stress or mental ill health in the staff they manage and should seek appropriate advice if they have concerns. In particular, managers should:

- promote a culture of open communication;
- plan work effectively and provide constructive feedback on performance;

- ensure staff receive the information and training needed for their work;
- monitor workloads and reallocate work where reasonably necessary;
- ensure staff understand the standards of behaviour expected of them and others, and address behaviour that falls below those standards.

7.3 External information and urgent support

Help and information may also be obtained from a GP, NHS 111, Mind at www.mind.org.uk or Samaritans at www.samaritans.org. These external services are independent of Simtec.

If a member of staff is considered to be at serious and immediate risk of self-harm or harming others, action must be taken straight away. The matter should be referred to the Managing Director or Health and Safety Lead, who will seek appropriate medical advice where reasonably practicable. Every reasonable effort will be made to contact an emergency contact nominated by the individual. Where necessary, the emergency services will be called. The wellbeing of the individual and those around them will always be the first concern.

8. ADDRESSING WORK-RELATED STRESS

If you believe you are suffering from work-related stress, you should discuss this with your line manager in the first instance. If you feel unable to do so, you should contact the Managing Director or Health and Safety Lead.

Once an issue affecting health comes to our attention, we will discuss with the individual what steps can be taken. Those steps may include:

- reviewing the current role, responsibilities, workload and working hours, with temporary adjustments agreed and reviewed where appropriate;
- investigating concerns where stress may have been caused by bullying, harassment or other inappropriate behaviour;
- seeking medical advice, treatment or a medical report from an appropriate medical adviser, specialist or the individual's GP, with appropriate consent;
- where the individual is absent through sickness, discussing an appropriate return-to-work programme and any reasonable adjustments.

9. ABSENCE DUE TO STRESS OR MENTAL ILL HEALTH

A person who is absent because of work-related stress or mental ill health should follow the sickness absence reporting procedure contained in their contract or otherwise communicated by Simtec.

In cases of prolonged or repeated absence, Simtec may apply an appropriate sickness absence or capability process, taking account of medical advice and its duties under the Equality Act 2010.

10. CONFIDENTIALITY

Information about stress, mental health and mental wellbeing is highly sensitive. Every member of staff must observe the high level of confidentiality required when dealing with such information, whether supporting a colleague or otherwise involved in the operation of a workplace policy or procedure. A breach of confidentiality may give rise to disciplinary or contractual action.

There are occasions when information may need to be shared, including:

- where steps are needed to address work-related stress, such as reallocating work within a team;
- where medical advice is required to support an individual or address concerns;

- where allegations of harassment, bullying or other misconduct require investigation or proceedings;
- where an individual presents an immediate danger to themselves or others.

Wherever possible, these matters will be discussed with the individual concerned before action is taken.

11. PROTECTION FOR THOSE REPORTING STRESS

Staff who report that they are suffering from work-related stress or mental ill health, support a colleague in making such a report, or participate in an investigation connected with this policy in good faith will be protected from intimidation or victimisation.

Anyone who believes they have been subjected to intimidation or victimisation should raise the matter with their line manager, the Managing Director or the Health and Safety Lead. A complaint may also be raised under the appropriate grievance procedure.

If, after investigation, a person is found to have provided false information in bad faith, they may be subject to disciplinary or contractual action.

12. REVIEW

The Managing Director and Health and Safety Lead will review this policy at least annually and following any significant concern, relevant legal change or material change to Simtec's workforce or working arrangements.

APPROVAL

Approved by: Joseph O'Sullivan, Managing Director



Signature:

Date: 26 August 2026